



Logged Healthy Anyway

Why Geocachers Skip the Maintenance Flag to Protect a Streak

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The problem

A geocache's displayed health status rests on what finders choose to log, not on a physical check of the container. The app assumes a struggling cache gets reported the way a healthy one does. Whether it actually does has gone untested.

Research questions

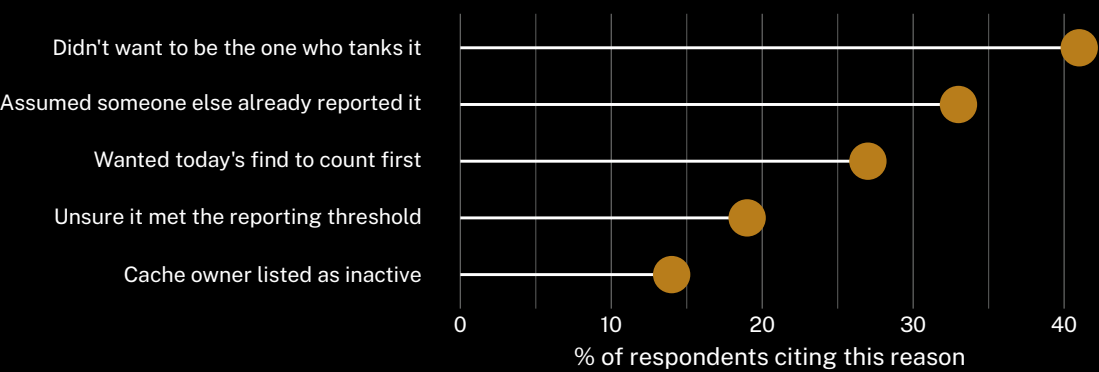
- How often does a finder who rates a container “poor” log a standard find rather than a maintenance flag?
- What reasons do finders give, in their own words, for withholding the flag?
- Does under-reporting track a finder's own lifetime find total?

Study design

- n = 214 active geocachers · online survey · self-selected via a regional caching forum and an in-app prompt · 6-week fielding window
- Most recent “poor”-condition find recalled; logged type and free-text reason captured
- Reason text double-coded to a pre-registered frame; disagreements adjudicated blind to the respondent's streak length

What we found

58% of finders recalling a container rated “poor” logged a standard Found It rather than a maintenance flag. Under-reporting concentrates among finders holding the longest lifetime streaks, rising from 31% of finders under 50 lifetime finds to 54% of finders at 500 or more.



The single most-cited reason for withholding a maintenance flag on a “poor”-rated container, among 214 geocachers surveyed 3 Jun–15 Jul 2026, was reluctance to be the one who lowers the cache's find rate for other seekers (41%).

Implications & takeaways

The health status a seeker checks before setting out reflects what finders were willing to admit, not what a container can still withstand. A stable minority (12%) report flagging every applicable find regardless of streak. Next: pairing self-report against an independent physical audit at the same coordinates.

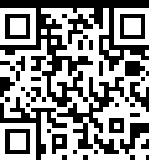
Selected references

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Survey responses de-identified prior to analysis; no cache coordinates or usernames retained by the research team.

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“Most finders know it's broken. Most log it as found anyway.”

58% of surveyed finders who rated a container “poor” logged a standard Found It (n = 214, 3 Jun–15 Jul 2026).